GENDERING MYANMAR STUDIES

In the scholarly literature on Myanmar, women's experiences of and responses to the conflict are commonly overlooked in favour of research situating ethnicity (Holliday 2010; Smith 2007) or the military (Callahan 2003) as the primary lens through which to understand political developments in the country. In this way, conflict is typically identified as being the result of differential colonial treatments of ethnic groups (Harriden 2002, p. 87; Holliday 2010, p. 117; Smith 2007, p. 15). This is problematic, as the focus on ethnicity and armed groups means that the roles and experiences of women in these conflicts have been largely left out of the picture, even though gender norms are critical for sustaining the war(s) practically and ideologically.

According to feminist scholars, gender roles are at the heart of the making of national collectives and thus, ethnic conflict. Yuval-Davis and Anthias (1989) have identified five ways that women have distinct roles in supporting and upholding ethnic nationalism. These include biological, cultural, and symbolic reproduction, as well as active participation in armed and national struggles, and as signifiers of collective difference (Yuval-Davis and Anthias 1989, p. 7).

Understanding nationalism as inherently gendered renders visible the importance of the gender order in the outbreak and sustainment of political upheaval and conflict in Myanmar. For example, a gender analysis would reveal how the Tatmadaw, in situating itself as the 'guardian' and 'protector' of the country (Callahan 2012; Walton 2012), uses a gendered script where it inhabits the paternal role to help justify its military rule. Understanding nationalism as inherently gendered would also explain the Tatmadaw's deliberate targeting of minority women for sexual violence because women are positioned as signifiers of the ethnic collective and because crimes committed in conflict areas enjoy impunity. A gender analysis would further demonstrate how women's exposure to sexual and gender-based violence depends on a gendered division of labour that results in women's exclusion from positions of power.

Understanding nationalism as inherently gendered highlights how conflict relies on narratives built around traditional notions of masculinity and femininity, where men are seen as the protectors and the warriors, and women as innocent and in need of protection (Elshtain 1987; Hansen 2001; Shepherd 2006). The construction of the gender order, then, plays